



Heartbreaking: Mirabai's Asian Games tragedy was one of the lowest moments of her career. AP

shoulder — that we otherwise couldn't target. That way, we made the best use of the time that we had. What could have been a disadvantage became an advantage," he adds.

While Sharma looked at the bright side of things, Mirabai says it was often difficult to come to terms with the fact that she had so much work to do. "It was very hard to just accept that I had to do bodyweight squats. At that time, it seemed my goal was so far away. My plan was to do 120kg in the clean and jerk and 90kg in the snatch [her personal bests are 119kg and 88kg, respectively], and now I can't even do free squats. I couldn't even lift my body weight at the start of the rehabilitation period. A lot of negative thoughts come into the mind at that time. But I kept telling myself that whatever has happened, I need to recover smartly. I have to steadily recover," she says.

So, Mirabai did what she had to do when she resumed weightlifting. That meant the lifetime supply of free pizza that she'd been awarded by Domino's after winning the Tokyo

silver would go unclaimed. "I love pizza, but I had to make sure my body weight didn't increase at all. Even though my mother was cooking for me, I managed to make sure that I didn't eat more than I should. I managed to stay inside 51kg at all times. That way, I knew I wasn't going to have to work to reduce my weight once I started training with the weights at the end of my rehab period," she says.

While losing six months of training might be a near-fatal career blow, Mirabai managed to recover almost entirely. "I was able to put back the weight on the bar almost right after I finished my rehabilitation period. Right now I'm feeling as strong as I did before the Tokyo Olympics," she says. That belief isn't just wishful thinking. Two months ago, in March this year, Mirabai competed at the

IWF Weightlifting World Cup in Thailand. It had been just three months after she lifted a weight for the first time since the Asian Games. She made five successful lifts out of a total of six attempts — lifting a best of 81kg in snatch and 103kg in clean and jerk. Although her total of 184kg was her lowest in over six years of competition and only placed her 11th overall, it was a mark that her coach was more than happy with. "She was starting out with almost nothing. And within three months, we were just about 10 percent off her best lifts," he says.

Now, though, Mirabai is a lot closer to her personal best. Although he won't give exact figures for fear of tipping off the rest of the field, Sharma says he is a very confident man. Even in the one relatively light training session that *Sportstar* visited,



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